

# Everyone Else • 36/39 • Husayn ibn Ruh al-Nawbakhti

**The Man Who Answered Without Answering.** Husayn served the third of the four terms, and was so careful with what he said that even his enemies could not catch him saying too much. Five items, no event print, dateless.

One style for the whole line — Fraunces and Nunito Sans, cut paper, the person on a stamp. Still open where it shows: the fact panel is TO VERIFY and the return address is not set.

ENVELOPE — C5, 229 × 162 MM

NOOR POST · EVERYONE ELSE

**Husayn served the third of the four terms, and was so careful with what he said that even his enemies could not catch him saying too much.**

FOR

**[Child's name]**



**HUSAYN IBN RUH AL-NAWBAKHTI**  
FIRST EDITION · 36/39



INSIDE THE FLAP

EVERYONE ELSE · HUSAYN  
IBN RUH AL-NAWBAKHTI ·  
INSIDE THE FLAP

## Open together.

● is the grown-up. ○ is you.

- 1 The letter — read it out loud, ● and ○ taking turns
- 2 The hadith card
- 3 The print
- 4 The stickers
- 5 The postcard

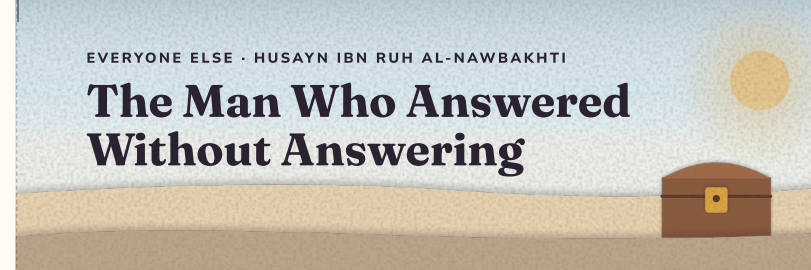


## Husayn ibn Ruh al-Nawbakhti

- **His background.** Born into the Nawbakhti family, well known in Baghdad for scholarship — unlike the first two deputies, he was a public figure before he ever took the post.
- **Who he served.** Third of the four trusted agents (*sufara'*) of Imam al-Mahdi, named by Muhammad ibn Uthman before his death.
- **What he was known for.** Extraordinary discretion under direct questioning — reports describe interrogators coming away satisfied without having learned anything usable.
- **What it cost him.** Imprisoned more than once during his term, by rulers who suspected the role without ever being able to prove it.
- **Why he is in this envelope.** *Husayn served the third of the four terms, and was so careful with what he said that even his enemies could not catch him saying too much.*

He died still holding the post, having named Ali ibn Muhammad al-Samarri as the fourth.

## The Man Who Answered Without Answering



● is the grown-up · ○ is you · ●○ is together

- The third man was nothing like the first two. No stall, no oil, no cover at all. He came from a family everyone in Baghdad already knew, and everyone already knew his name.

### ○ Isn't that backwards?

- It should have ruined him. The first two hid behind an ordinary trade. He could not hide behind anything, so he did the other thing instead.

### ○ Which was?

- He learned to answer everything and give away nothing.

### ○ You can do both?

- He could. A government man once questioned him for a long stretch — circling back, rephrasing, trying to get a name out of him — and went away with nothing he could use. By some accounts he went away pleased with how it had gone.

### ○ Did they ever catch him?

#### THE MAN WHO ANSWERED WITHOUT ANSWERING · CONTINUED

- Never with anything in his hands. They jailed him more than once anyway, on suspicion alone, held him, learned nothing, and let him out again exactly as suspicious as when they took him in.

#### ◦ **What was he protecting?**

- Names. Ordinary people, in a dozen cities, who had trusted him with letters and with money. One careless sentence in one long conversation and somebody he had never met would have paid for it.

#### ◦ **How do you even learn that?**

- Slowly, and by deciding beforehand. You work out what you will not say before you are ever asked, because nobody makes that decision well in the middle of being questioned. Then you answer generously about everything else, so the silence has somewhere to hide.

#### ◦ **Did he pick the next one too?**

- He did — Ali ibn Muhammad al-Samarri, the fourth and last. Three handovers by then, each man naming the next while he was still alive to be argued with.

#### ◦ **Could you guard a name for years? Say if you could.**

- Very few people can. Most of us give a thing away tired, or cornered, or wanting to be liked. He was all three at times and still did not.

#### SAY THIS ONE TOGETHER

•◦

**He answered every  
question they had. He  
told them nothing.**



Then the hadith card.



FIRST EDITION · 36/39

**NO SAYING SELECTED**

Blocked on a source — nothing prints here until  
its row on citation-sheet.md reads V

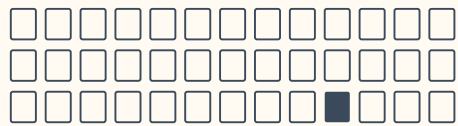


NOT A SILSILA SEGMENT · THIS SET HAS ITS OWN CHAIN

NOOR POST · EVERYONE ELSE

The other chain

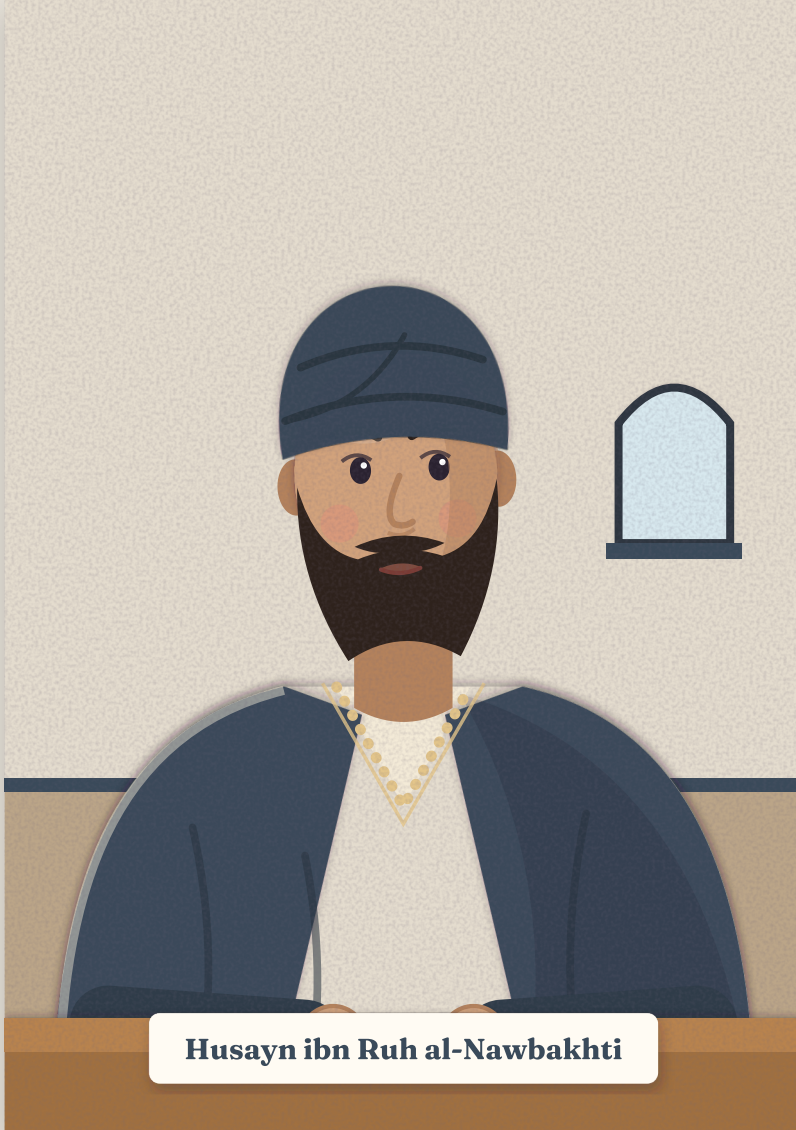
The box holds fourteen cards, one for each of the Fourteen.  
This set is the people around them: thirty-nine cards, collected  
in any order.



First edition · thirty-nine cards

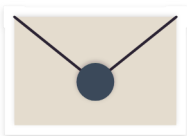
**Blocked:** Same as 35 — Kitab al-Ghayba held, no conduct-register  
tawqi' found.

Back — its own chain, no silsila number

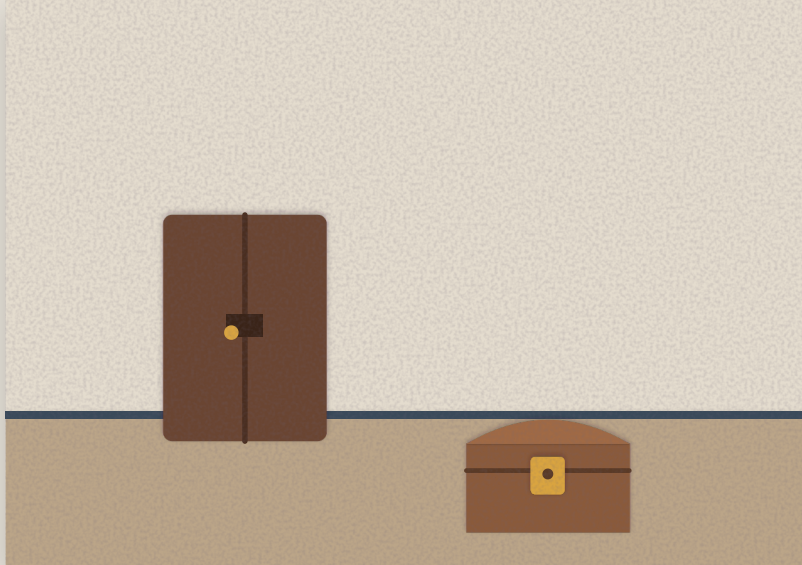


**Husayn ibn Ruh al-Nawbakhti**









**We opened this one  
together.**

- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_

*Post it back to us, or keep it. Either is right.*



**Noor Post**

[ Return address — not set ]

---

---

